The true power of *Making Visible*—the inaugural show at Kolkata gallery Experimenter's new Mumbai outpost—comes from the arrangement of the works and the fact that displays aren't interrupted with lengthy, explanatory notes. The show, which will run until October 29, presents Dhaka-based Ayesha Sultana's body of work—paintings, drawings and sculptures that connect a range of interests, everything from space and architecture to emotion. In the absence of descriptions, viewers can experience the artworks and interpret them as they will. And in works positioned near windows, where daylight spontaneously becomes a part of the artwork—lending an ephemeral sparkle to shards in an untitled concrete and glass installation, for instance—the viewer's feelings may change with the hour.

Sultan's body of work connects a range of interests, everything from space and architecture to emotion

The shimmering graphite relief works, for which Sultana is best known, are inspired by the shapes in the windows, niches, and gates of Dhaka. The works capture oft-overlooked moments in time as well as the objects one fails to see in everyday life. Water and fluidity are also recurrent themes in her works. Aluminium puddles wrap around corners and walls are splattered with oversized brass droplets. In imbuing metals with the nature of water, Sultana invites viewers to look closer, perhaps to challenge their perception of what they believe they know, or to allow room for some fluidity of thought.

Paintings of the ocean stretching into infinity seem to reflect personal emotions—with choppy waves urging you to deliberate on the stillness and the void below. Indeed, many of the works seem reflective in some way. In one of the smaller artworks, we see tiny specks of silver bring alive the frightening strength of a tumultuous ocean, giving voice to its rhythm while compelling one to look inwards, to dive into the chaos of one's own thoughts in the quiet room. Once again, this artwork appears to have its roots in the artist's fascination with water, something that was forged through Sultana's travels. Sultana hails from Bangladesh, but has studied in Lahore and exhibited her work in Kolkata, Slovenia and New York.

Interestingly, the ebb and flow of tides is also mirrored in the artist's 'Breath Count' series of drawings. Created by scratching the surface of clay-coated paper, the show's concept note says, "[Breath Count is] a contemplation of the interconnectedness of her own body to larger systems. Cutting into the surface of the paper, Sultana reveals patterns that represent a delicate inward probe using time, rhythm and removal in breath." Calm and rhythmic in moments and erratic and urgent in other frames, this record in clay is perhaps the most captivating work in the room. And seeing how the world is finally catching its breath after over two years, it seems to capture the artist's state of mind, but also, albeit unwittingly, our collective consciousness. ■

Anjana Vaswani







IN SHARP FOCUS Pictures clicked at (left and right) Sitaram Digital Studio and Prince Studio in Bhavnagar, Gujarat, and (middle) Harish Photo Studio, Faridabad, Haryana

out to create images that were unique of people that were special against often painterly backdrops and subdued lighting. I never carried a flash or a tripod or lights. I just used what I found. "The gaze and the aesthetics took shape during the process. Sheth had no prior boxes to tick—she was going wherever these stories took her. "When shooting, you never really say, 'Oh I need to balance this with that or focus on this,' as it all happens quite intuitively at the time of taking pictures."

Sheth's images can take many meanings. In one of the pictures, a schoolgirl poses with her legs stretched, grinning with glee. In another, a middle-aged man poses nonchalantly with his lips pursed. Mumbai, for its part, also finds newer languages to express itself through the photographer's lenses. "It is a city I belong to and engage with regardless of its jams and digging and bursting population," says Sheth. "It teems with energy like nowhere else in the country and people just get on. I would like to do a future project in the city and I already have some ideas. I usually engage with one thing and dig deeper, so let's see where this takes me." ■

Arman Khan